

MVP FEASIBILITY REPORT · 2026

Acumen.

Practise judgement before it counts.

Acumen helps emerging business leaders practise realistic decisions, understand their leadership tendencies, and connect with peers whose strengths complement their own.

PRODUCT

Acumen
Web app prototype

MODULE

MSIN0144
Group Coursework

GROUP 47

Daniel Dutulescu
Maya Munasinghe
Moritz Bode

DATE

1 May 2026

CONTENTS

What's inside

01	Executive summary	02
02	Scope and opportunity	03
03	Product definition	04
04	MVP walkthrough	05
05	Technology and implementation	07
06	Business model, revenue and cost	09
07	Market validation	11
08	Market attractiveness	14
09	Feasibility and next steps	17
A	Appendix · Business Model Canvas	19
A	Appendix · Value Proposition Canvas	20
B	Appendix · Research instruments	21
C	Appendix · Group charter and meetings	22
D	Bibliography	24

01 · EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A feasible MVP for emerging leaders

Young people preparing for management roles are taught about leadership but rarely get to practise it. Case studies are abstract, internships are scarce, and traditional psychometrics are slow, expensive, and detached from the work itself. **Acumen** addresses this gap with short, scenario-driven simulations that surface how a user actually decides under pressure.

The beachhead is business students, young professionals, and aspiring founders; the premium later segment is next-generation (*NextGen*) successors in Asia-Pacific family businesses where leadership transitions carry significant economic stakes [3][1]. The MVP demonstrates a four-step loop, **Simulate, Signal, Connect, Improve**, across three live web scenarios. The model layers freemium individual access, university cohort pilots, and a premium NextGen pathway; a 15-response survey and three in-depth interviews give directional evidence, supported by one clearly marked composite survey voice.

Verdict. Acumen is feasible as an early MVP, the simulation, feedback, and peer-discovery loop is demonstrated. Further user testing and scoring validation are needed before high-stakes use.

Optional questions addressed: **first customers** (\$2, \$7), **market size** (\$2), **underlying technology** (\$5).

Why now, and who this is actually for

Three forces converge: a generation of young leaders who lack practical experience, a documented succession bottleneck in Asia-Pacific family businesses, and growing acceptance of simulation-based assessment in serious professional contexts.

Who Acumen is built for

Acumen is built for anyone deciding earlier than expected, students running a society or capstone, early-career professionals promoted before training catches up, aspiring founders making a first hire. The common thread: they have read about leadership but not practised it, and the first poor call is paid in reputation. NextGen successors are the highest-willingness-to-pay later segment, on top of a much larger pool with the same problem.

SEGMENT	TRIGGER TO USE ACUMEN	WHERE WE REACH THEM
Business and engineering students	Recruiting, society leadership, capstone projects	UCL, society partnerships, course tie-ins
Young professionals (0-4 years)	First promotion, first hire, first cross-functional decision	LinkedIn communities, employer learning & development programmes
Aspiring founders	Pre-incorporation, first co-founder hire, first investor pitch	Accelerators, founder communities, university entrepreneurship offices
NextGen successors (later)	Joining family business, governance training	Family-office networks, regional advisors

The "leadership-readiness" gap

Business education is rich in frameworks but poor in practice; internships compress months into weeks of memos, and graduate schemes defer decision authority to year two or three. Serious games increasingly assess soft skills [14], and McKinsey's Game-Based Innovation Lab shows simulation-based assessment now sits inside serious professional contexts [4].

Why an Asia-Pacific focus

The premium segment is concentrated in Asia-Pacific, where ~85% of regional businesses are family firms and a generational handover is underway. **USD 5.8 trillion** transfers between 2023 and 2030 [3]; 20% of the top 750 global family businesses are Asia-based, with ~USD 2 trillion collective revenue [15]. Only ~13% of large Southeast Asian family firms transition leadership successfully [16], and PwC finds 43% of Indonesian NextGen citing senior resistance [1]. Succession transfers responsibility and decision pressure, not just wealth, and that is the gap Acumen exists to address.

Market sizing (top-down, 2024 figures)

LAYER	DEFINITION	SIZE	SOURCE / ASSUMPTION
TAM	Global early-career professionals + business/management students	~50 m+	UNESCO tertiary enrolments; OECD 0-5 yr graduates.
SAM	UK business/management students + APAC NextGen pool	~250 k	HESA 2023/24 (~220 k); PwC NextGen cohort [2].
SOM (Y1)	UCL beachhead via society + course tie-ins	~5,000	~400 paid unlocks plus 3 cohort licences (~8% paid conversion).

What Acumen is

Acumen helps emerging business leaders practise realistic decisions, understand their leadership tendencies, and connect with peers whose strengths complement their own.

The product is one repeatable loop. Each session begins with a realistic scenario under time and information constraints, then converts the user's choices into a research-informed leadership signal. The signal is developmental, not diagnostic, it points toward what to practise next and toward peers whose strengths complement their own.

The framing draws on established theory: upper-echelons [10], Vroom-Yetton [11], Hersey-Blanchard [12], and Rest [13], informing how decisions, participation, readiness, and ethical prompts are structured.

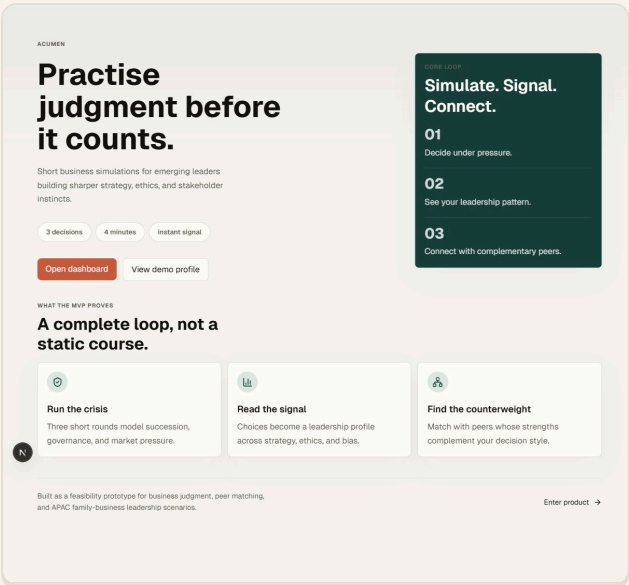


FIG. 1 Acumen introduces a simple promise: practise business judgement before it counts.

The product loop

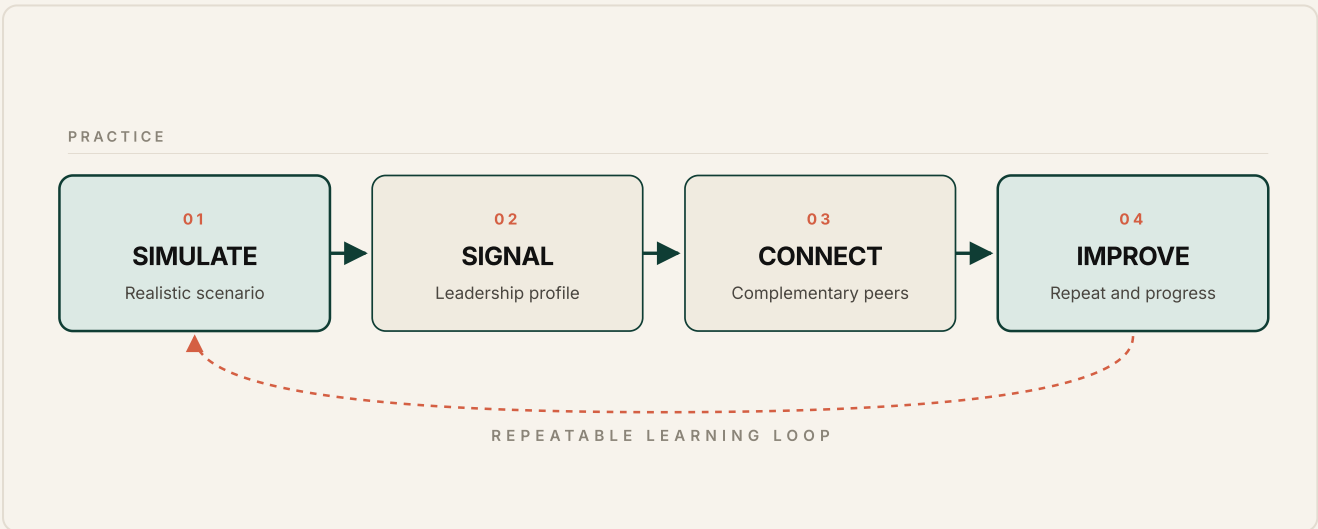


FIG. 2 Acumen turns business learning into a repeatable loop: users practise realistic decisions, receive feedback, connect with useful peers, and return to improve.

How a user actually uses Acumen

The walkthrough shows Acumen's core loop: a user enters via a simple value proposition, completes a simulation, receives a leadership signal, and is guided toward complementary peers, and now, conversations with them.

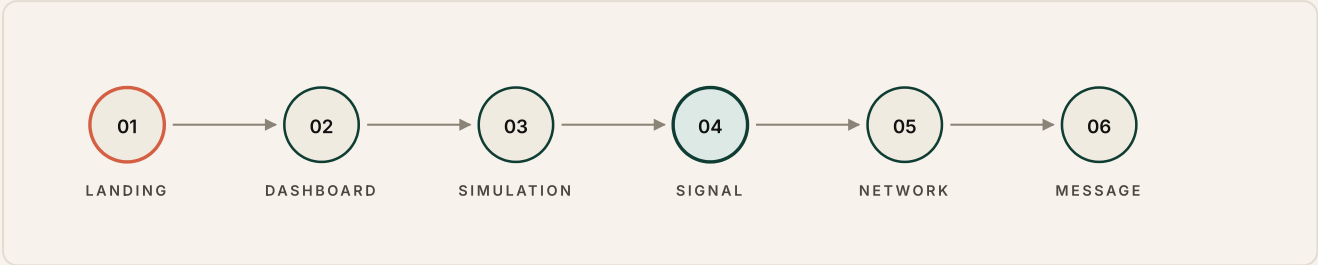


FIG. 3 Updated six-step user journey, including peer messaging.

Step 1 · Onboarding

A first-time user lands on a single-promise home screen and is taken into a short onboarding flow. Acumen asks what the user wants to develop, decision-making under pressure, ethical judgement, conflict navigation, or strategic communication, and these selections shape scenario order and feedback framing.

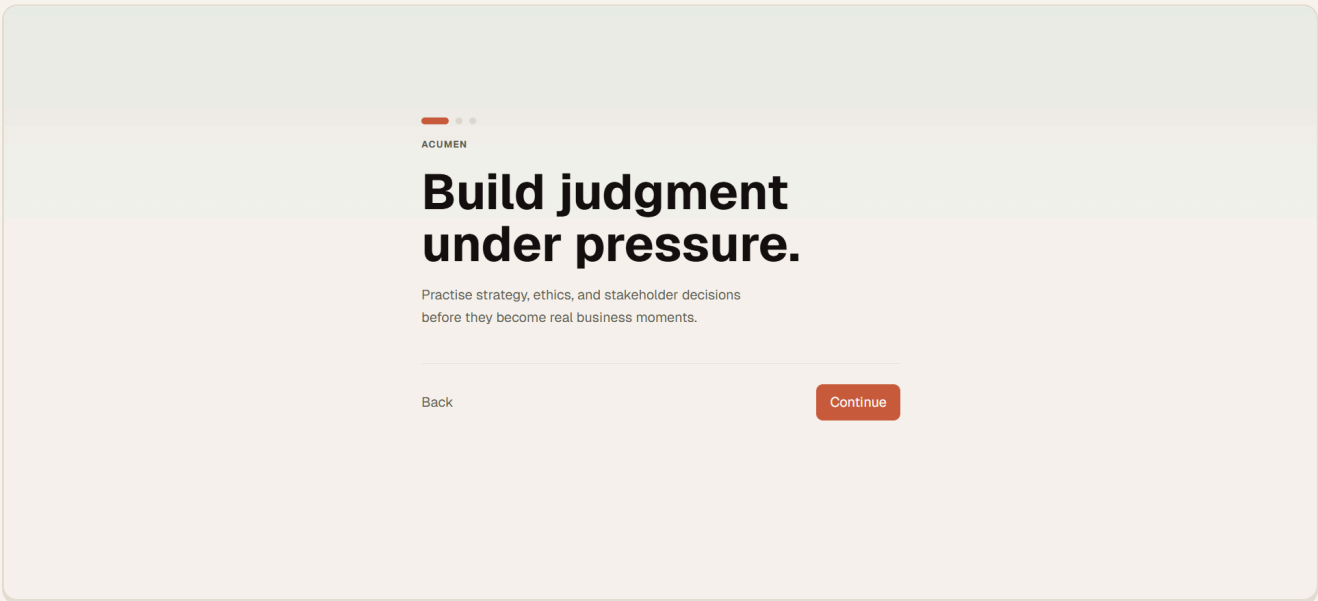


FIG. 4 Onboarding frames the experience around goals and skill development.

Dashboard and simulation

Step 2 · Dashboard

After onboarding the user lands on a personal dashboard with three live scenarios, *The Succession Crisis*, *The Authority Bypass*, and *The Fading Division*, alongside a top-line cognitive profile and a "next focus" prompt that points to the dimension worth strengthening on the next run.

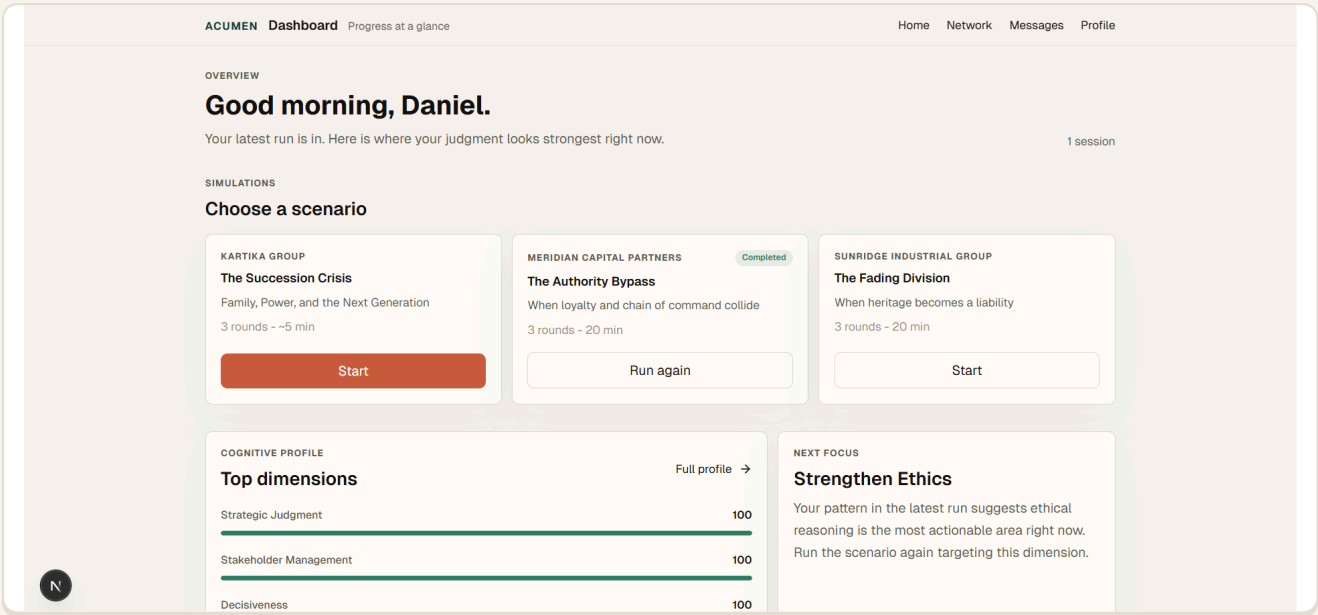


FIG. 5 The dashboard surfaces three live scenarios, the user's top dimensions, and a next-focus prompt.

Step 3 · Simulation

Each scenario presents sequenced decisions under time and information constraints. The user reviews stakeholder documents, sees situational prompts, and selects an option, with optional ethical follow-ups and a final twist. Below: a live round of *The Authority Bypass* inside the Meridian Capital scenario.

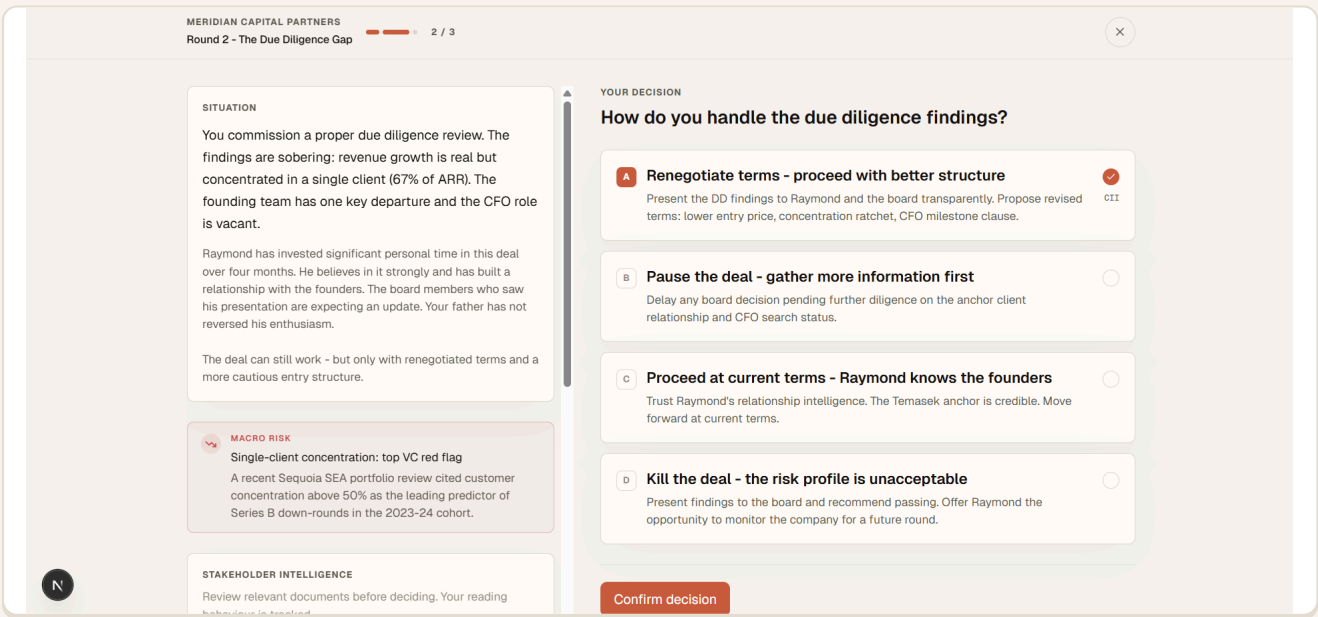


FIG. 6 A simulation round in *The Authority Bypass*, with stakeholder context, decision options, and macro-flag warnings.

From signal to profile

Step 4 · A research-informed signal

At the close of a simulation Acumen maps decisions to five dimensions , strategic judgement, ethical reasoning, stakeholder management, decisiveness, adaptability, as developmental feedback, not a graded score. The numerical output is not yet a calibrated psychometric [5][8]; what the MVP demonstrates is the strategy mapping (each decision traceable to a research-grounded tag).

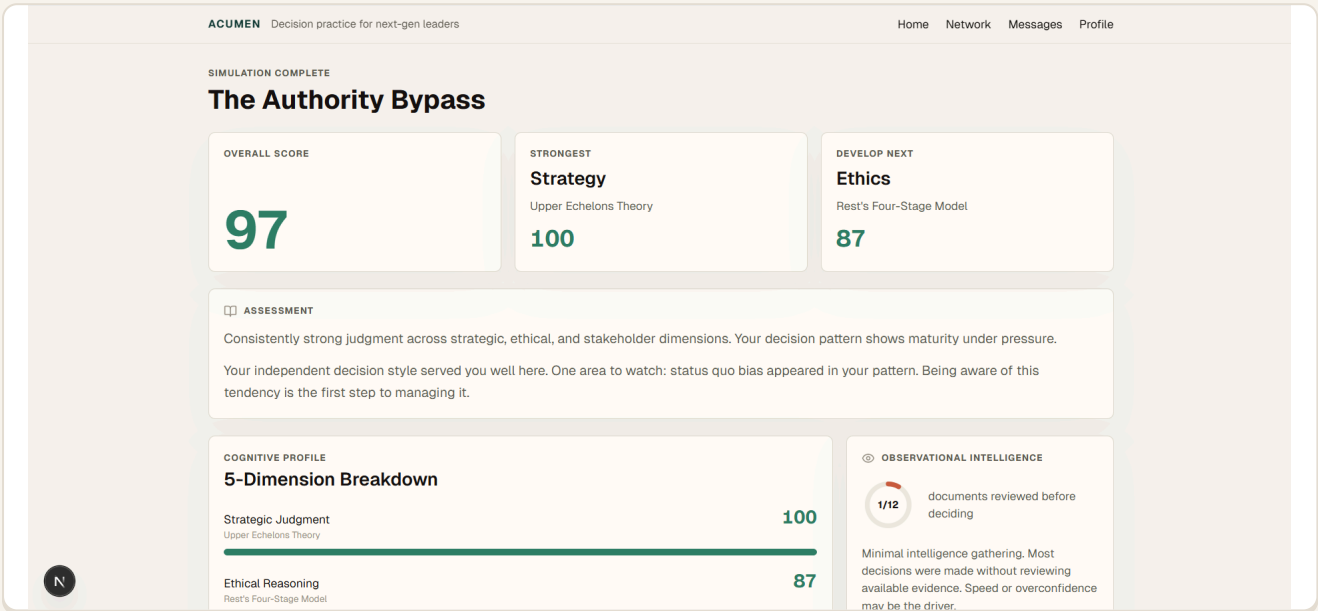


FIG. 7 Per-run feedback: overall score, strongest dimension, the dimension to develop next, and a five-dimension breakdown.

Step 5 · Profile and progress

The same profile vector aggregates across runs into a current-profile view with five dimension bars and a session history. Repetition is what turns the loop into learning, the profile records how a user's signal shifts over time as *The Fading Division* and other scenarios broaden practice beyond succession.

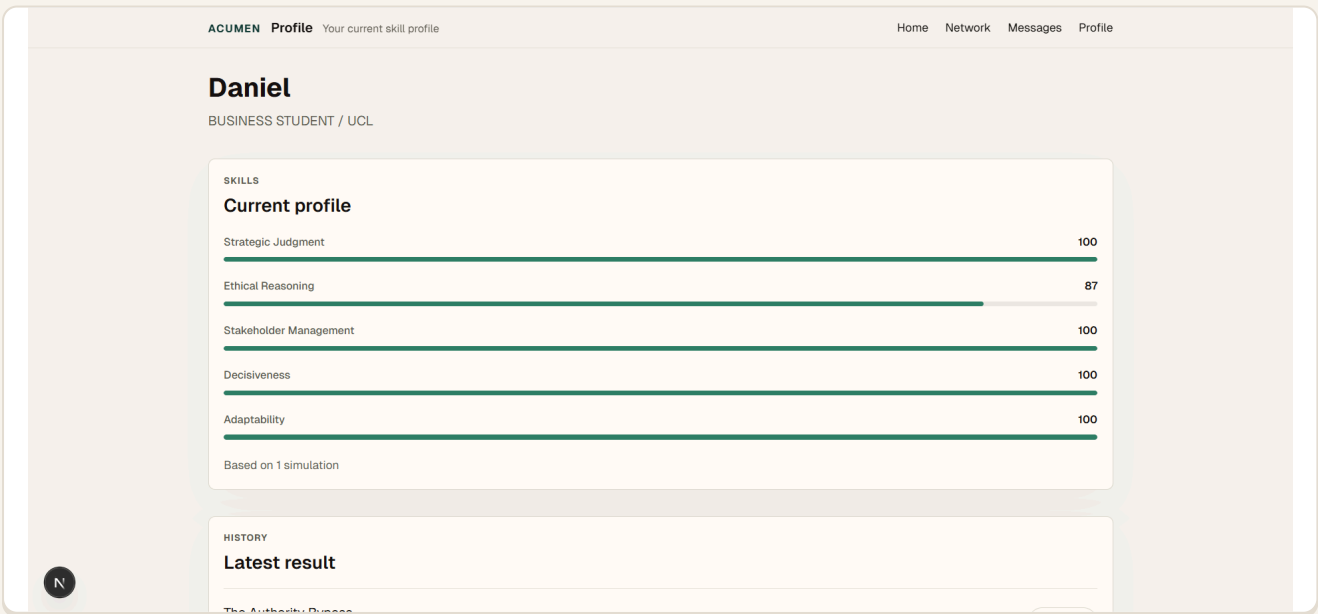


FIG. 8 The profile aggregates results across runs into five-dimension bars and a session history.

Network and conversation

Step 6 · Peer matching

The signal then suggests peers with complementary strengths, the same simulated experience produces a common vocabulary for collaboration. MVP matching uses profile-vector similarity over decision tendencies; a swipe-style mobile interaction is on the 6-12-month roadmap.

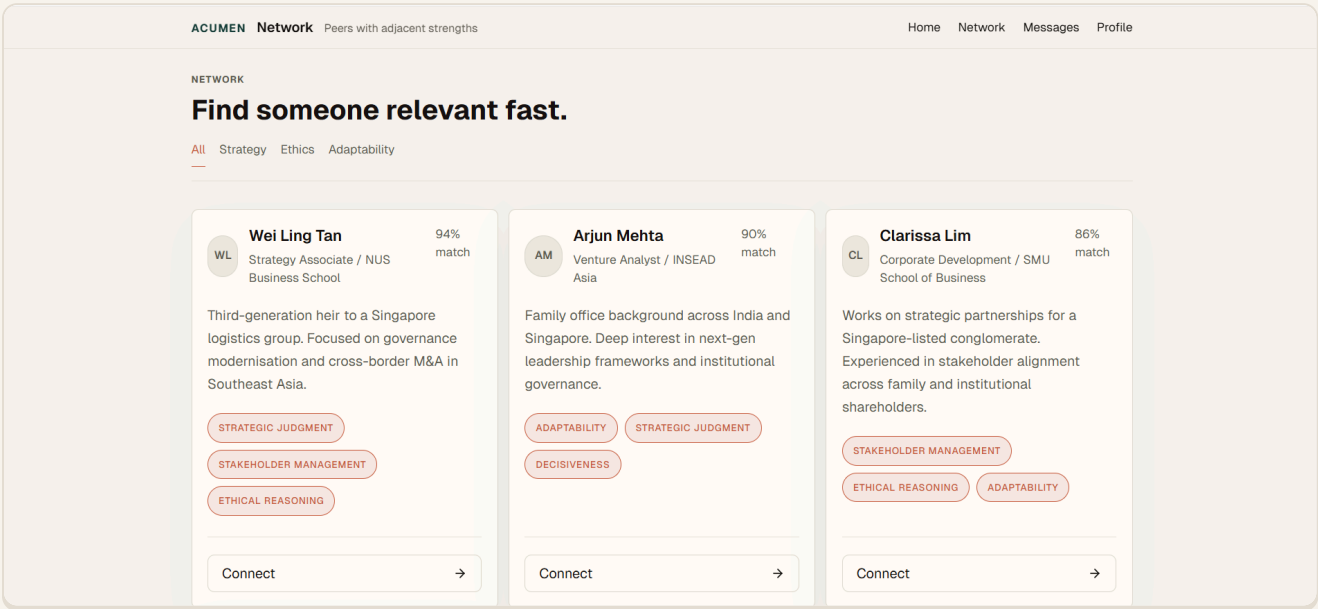


FIG. 9 Peer matching surfaces complementary strengths rather than identical profiles.

Step 7 · Direct messaging

Once two users connect, the messaging surface opens with a scenario- specific prompt, for example, *"compare your scenario paths"* , so the conversation starts on shared substance rather than a cold introduction. This was the highest-leverage change after Round 2 interviews flagged that LinkedIn-style networks felt shallow.

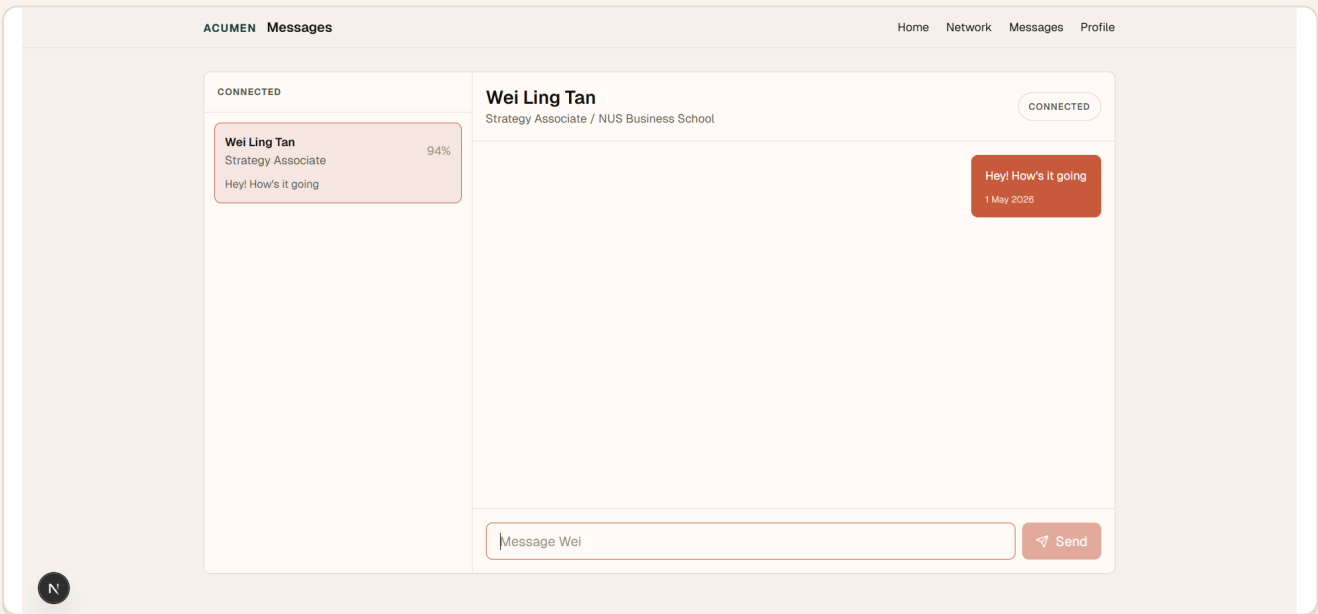


FIG. 10 Messaging opens on a scenario-specific prompt so connections start on shared substance, not introductions.

What actually has to work

On the surface Acumen is a simple web app. Underneath, three pieces actually carry the product risk: the simulation engine, the scoring system, and peer matching. Everything else is the kind of plumbing every web product needs.

The three components that matter

SIMULATION ENGINE A small state machine takes the user through four phases: deciding, ethical, twist, and complete. Each scenario is just typed data (situation, options, stakeholder documents, hidden tags), so we can write new ones without touching the engine.	SCORING SYSTEM Every choice the user makes carries a hidden tag. We roll those up into five scores: strategic judgement, ethical reasoning, stakeholder management, decisiveness, and adaptability. Each one ties back to established leadership theory (Upper Echelons, Vroom-Yetton, Hersey-Blanchard, Rest, OODA). The expert-rater calibration is on the roadmap.	PEER MATCHING We match peers by complement, not similarity. At MVP scale it runs against demo profiles; real matching only starts to mean something around fifty active users, which is why the cohort pilot matters.
--	---	---

Stack and architecture

LAYER	CHOICE	WHY
Framework	Next.js with React and TypeScript	Routing across distinct app views (landing, onboarding, simulation, feedback, profile, network); types make the data model self-documenting.
Styling	Tailwind CSS; shared visual system in <code>globals.css</code>	Editorial palette stays consistent across pages without a heavy design system.
Interaction	Lucide React icons; Framer Motion for transitions	Animation is restrained; transitions punctuate the loop rather than decorate it.
State	Global React context provider; persisted to <code>localStorage</code> with hydration check	The demo journey survives page refreshes; protected pages do not redirect before saved state has loaded.
Scenario data	Strongly-typed TypeScript data files	New scenarios are added as data, not code. <i>The Succession Crisis</i> , <i>The Authority Bypass</i> , and <i>The Fading Division</i> already use this pattern.
Auth and data	Email login; anonymised profile vectors only	Reduces compliance surface and is honest with users about what is collected.

From decision to signal

How a decision becomes a signal

When a user starts a scenario the engine reads the typed data and shows them the situation, the options on the table, and any stakeholder documents. They make a call, sometimes get an ethical follow-up, often a final twist, and then they're done. The full sequence of choices goes through the scoring function, which looks up the hidden tags, applies basic bias detection, and produces an overall score, a five-dimension breakdown, and a Vroom-Yetton-style label. The feedback page renders all of that as plain-language summaries with dimension bars. That same profile vector is also what powers matching on the network page.

Honest limitations and IP

Right now Acumen is a research-backed prototype, not a fully validated psychometric tool, which would require further psychological studies. Our scoring relies on established frameworks but has not yet been validated against real-world performance outcomes; peer matching runs on demo data; and CV parsing, interactive maps, recruiter dashboards, and formal certificates are not part of the MVP.

Our defensible IP is not the codebase, which can be cloned in weeks, but three things that compound:

- **The scenario library.** Built on typed structured data, expert-reviewed before every release.
- **The calibrated feedback rubric.** Grounded in Upper Echelons, Vroom-Yetton, Hersey-Blanchard, and Rest, with expert-rater calibration scheduled as R5.
- **Cohort-pilot network density.** Match quality grows with usage; closed cohort pilots give us a head start a thin late entrant cannot match on day one.

All three sit with the founding team; trade-mark filing is budgeted in Year-1 legal costs.

A staged path to market

Acumen's business model is built around staged market entry, not a single target customer. The Business Model Canvas describes the broad beachhead; the Value Proposition Canvas focuses on the premium later segment. The relationship between them is sequential, not contradictory.

Beachhead via the BMC

Acumen pursues business students, young professionals, and aspiring founders, reachable via universities and societies, low acquisition cost, fast feedback loops. Revenue: freemium with paid scenario packs.

Premium via the VPC

The VPC focuses on NextGen successors in Asia-Pacific family businesses, pains are structural (senior resistance, no safe space to practise difficult decisions [1]). Revenue: institutional pilots, only after the loop is proven on the broader beachhead.

Revenue streams

Three streams: freemium individual → paid scenario pack (live), institutional cohort licences (in outreach), premium NextGen programme (roadmap).

STREAM	PRICE POINT	YEAR-1 TARGET VOLUME	YEAR-1 REVENUE (ILLUSTRATIVE)
Individual scenario pack	£9 one-off	400 unlocks	£3,600
University cohort licence	£1,500 per society / cohort	3 institutions	£4,500
NextGen pilot programme	£6,000 per cohort (scoped down)	1 paid pilot	£6,000
Total Year-1 revenue (target)			£14,100

Reasoning: 400 unlocks ≈ 8% conversion of the ~5,000 freemium pool; 3 of 6 cohort licences in outreach (50% close); NextGen scoped to one £6,000 cohort. Net of £11,500 cost ≈ £2,600 surplus.

Cost structure

Cost base is light at MVP stage: scenario authoring, serverless hosting, small UCL-focused marketing. Founder time shadow-priced, not drawn.

LINE	YEAR-1 ESTIMATE	NOTES
Scenario authoring and expert review	£6,000	~20 scenarios at MVP cost; expert review on contributor agreement.
Hosting and infrastructure	£1,200	Serverless backend; cost scales with usage.
Marketing and acquisition	£2,000	UCL events, organic content, founder outreach. No paid ads, exclusivity is part of the proposition.
Tooling, design, legal	£2,300	Trade-mark filing, design tooling, contractor support.
Total Year-1 cost	£11,500	Founder time is shadow-priced, not drawn.

First-year cash flow and roadmap

Year-1 cash trajectory

Costs spread evenly (~£960/month); scenario unlocks begin in month 3, cohort licences close in months 6, 8, 10, and the scoped-down NextGen pilot closes in month 9. Cumulative cash dips to ~-£4,200 in month 5 then recovers to **+£2,600** by year-end. The trough is founder-funded; founder time is not drawn as salary.

Now / Next / Later

NOW · MVP

- Three live web scenarios
- Research-informed feedback profile
- Peer discovery via profile similarity
- Freemium plus paid scenario pack

NEXT · 6-12 MONTHS

- iOS and Android build for public launch
- Swipe-style peer matching on mobile (dating-app interaction model)
- Additional scenarios across functions
- UCL and society cohort pilots
- First paying institutional licence

LATER · 12-24 MONTHS

- Institutional pilots at scale
- Verified completion certificates
- NextGen succession pathway
- B2B advisory or recruiter tools

Out of scope at MVP. CV parsing, global map matching, paid certificates, recruiter dashboards, and fully validated scoring sit on the roadmap rather than in the current product.

What users have told us so far

Three in-depth interviews and a short survey test early assumptions on the problem and the prototype. The sample is small, so the evidence is directional. Its main value is showing what to test next.

How we ran it

Three in-depth, semi-structured 20-25 minute interviews (a final-year UCL student, an early-career professional, and a pre-incorporation founder) followed a three-part guide: **pain points, concept reaction, willingness to pay** (full guide in Appendix B). A parallel online survey returned **15 responses** from UCL networks (8 aspiring entrepreneurs, 6 students, and 1 NextGen family-business inheritor). Directional only.

Survey snapshot, n = 15

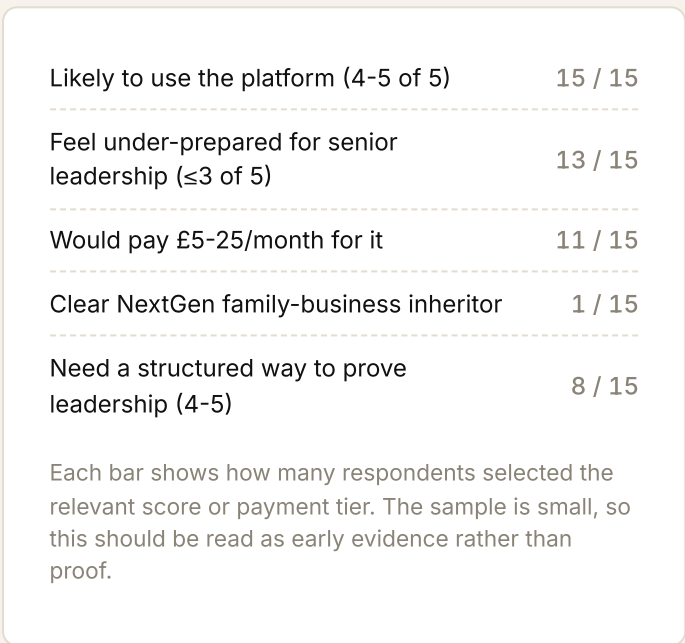


FIG. 9 Problem-statement and intent, n = 15.

Voices from interviews and survey free text

"The hardest part is not knowing if a decision was actually a good one. You make the call, things happen, and you never get told why."

INTERVIEWEE A · FINAL-YEAR STUDENT

"LinkedIn is fine for the photo at a conference. It's not where you find the person you'd phone before a hard meeting."

INTERVIEWEE B · EARLY-CAREER PROFESSIONAL

"Making decisions that disappoint people and still standing by them. Easy when everyone agrees, much harder with incomplete information, conflicting interests, and real consequences."

INTERVIEWEE C · ASPIRING ENTREPRENEUR, FAMILY-BUSINESS BACKGROUND

"Getting respect and being taken seriously is one of the hardest things, especially when you are leading people close to your own age."

SURVEY RESPONDENT · ASPIRING ENTREPRENEUR

Reaction to the prototype

Each interviewee was walked through the Acumen prototype after the pain-point discussion. Survey respondents (n = 15) answered the same closing prompts as a 5-point scale plus one free-text item. Three signals matter most here: intention to try, self-rated preparedness, and willingness to pay.

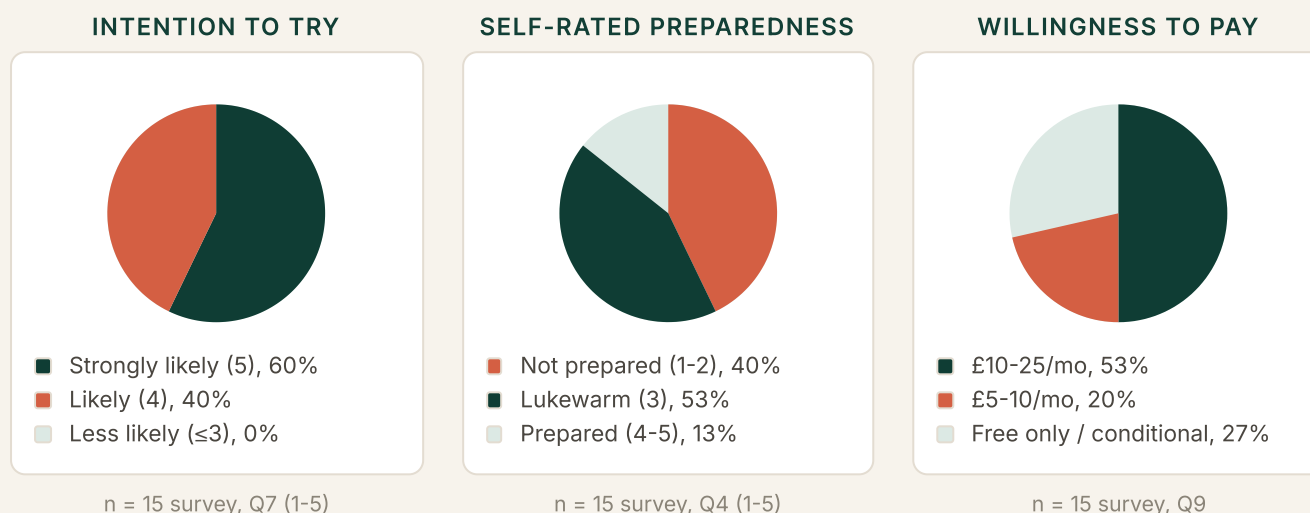


FIG. 10 Distribution of survey responses on intention to try the platform, self-rated leadership preparedness, and willingness to pay (n = 15).

Themes from free-text answers

Across the free-text answers to "what is the hardest part of becoming an effective leader?", four themes recurred:

- **Credibility and respect.** Three respondents named being taken seriously by an older or more experienced group as the hardest part, particularly relevant when leading peers in the same age band.
- **Decision-making with stakes.** One respondent put it precisely: *"making decisions that disappoint people and still standing by them."*
- **Buy-in and stakeholder management.** Several respondents pointed at the difficulty of leading without formal authority, of getting buy-in from older or more senior stakeholders.
- **Experience and network gap.** Two respondents framed the gap as not lack of ability but lack of exposure to real stakes; this is the gap Acumen targets directly.

Free-text Q5 across n = 15; coded by the team.

Why the founder concern matters

Our founder interviewee was the most strategically useful voice of the three. At very early founder stage, decision practice feels less urgent than product or fundraising; the same concern appeared in three founder free-text survey responses. The response is not to widen Acumen's scope but to position it honestly: it helps anyone deciding earlier than expected, not as a replacement for product or commercial skill-building.

What we heard, and what changed

Patterns across the three interviews

With only three conversations, we report what was said rather than how many agreed. The matrix below records, per interviewee, whether each topic was raised unprompted, raised after prompting, or not raised, a record, not a quantitative finding.

TOPIC	A · STUDENT	B · PRO	C · FOUNDER
Wanted feedback on past decisions	● Unprompted	⦿ After prompt	○ Not raised
LinkedIn-style networks felt shallow	● Unprompted	● Unprompted	⦿ After prompt
Preferred interactive over course-style	● Unprompted	● Unprompted	● Unprompted
Would prefer to use on mobile	● Unprompted	● Unprompted	● Unprompted
Concerned about thin user base at launch	○ Not raised	● Unprompted	⦿ After prompt
Sceptical of "scoring" framing	⦿ After prompt	● Unprompted	⦿ After prompt
Sceptical of leadership practice as a priority	○ Not raised	○ Not raised	● Unprompted
Would pay for skill, not certificates	⦿ After prompt	● Unprompted	⦿ After prompt

● Raised without prompting ⦿ Raised after prompt ○ Not raised in this interview

What changed because of the interviews

Four product decisions followed: the leadership signal was reframed as developmental, not diagnostic; peer matching moved earlier in the journey; the mobile build was promoted from "later" to "launch" (all three interviewees preferred phone use); copy and onboarding were rewritten to be honest about scope.

The cold-start concern

Interviewee B raised the sharpest concern: *"the matching only works if there are actually people in there worth meeting."* Response: a cohort-pilot model, closed UCL society pilots so everyone starts on the same day, guaranteeing a meaningful network at first contact.

What still needs testing

Three open questions inform R1, R2, R6: whether users return, whether the signal is understood without a facilitator, and whether a society signs a paying pilot. Next validation: a 40-user UCL cohort with telemetry on completion, return, and peer-message rates.

SWOT and competitive structure

Two short analyses: SWOT for internal position, Porter for external market structure.

SWOT

STRENGTHS

- Clear simulation-based MVP
- Strong link to leadership readiness research
- Broad student beachhead with premium NextGen pathway
- Differentiated blend of decision practice and networking

WEAKNESSES

- Scoring is research-informed, not validated
- Peer matching is still demo data
- Some roadmap features are not implemented
- Needs more user testing before stronger claims

OPPORTUNITIES

- Universities and societies can provide early cohorts
- APAC family-business succession is a high-value later market
- Simulations can become more culturally specific over time
- Peer network can create retention if enough users join

THREATS

- Generic AI coaching tools may look like substitutes
- McKinsey, LinkedIn, Coursera, or assessment firms could move into simulations
- Weak validation could damage credibility
- Users may see feedback as generic if not explained well

What the SWOT actually tells us

Strengths cluster around clarity and design, the loop is easy to explain, research grounding is verifiable, and the practice + network proposition is differentiated. Weaknesses cluster around proof: the feedback model is research-informed but not calibrated, matching uses demo data. Opportunities are addressable short-term via cohort pilots; threats are competitive, sharpening the case for validation over feature breadth. Closing the evidence gap matters more than building anything new.

Porter's Five Forces

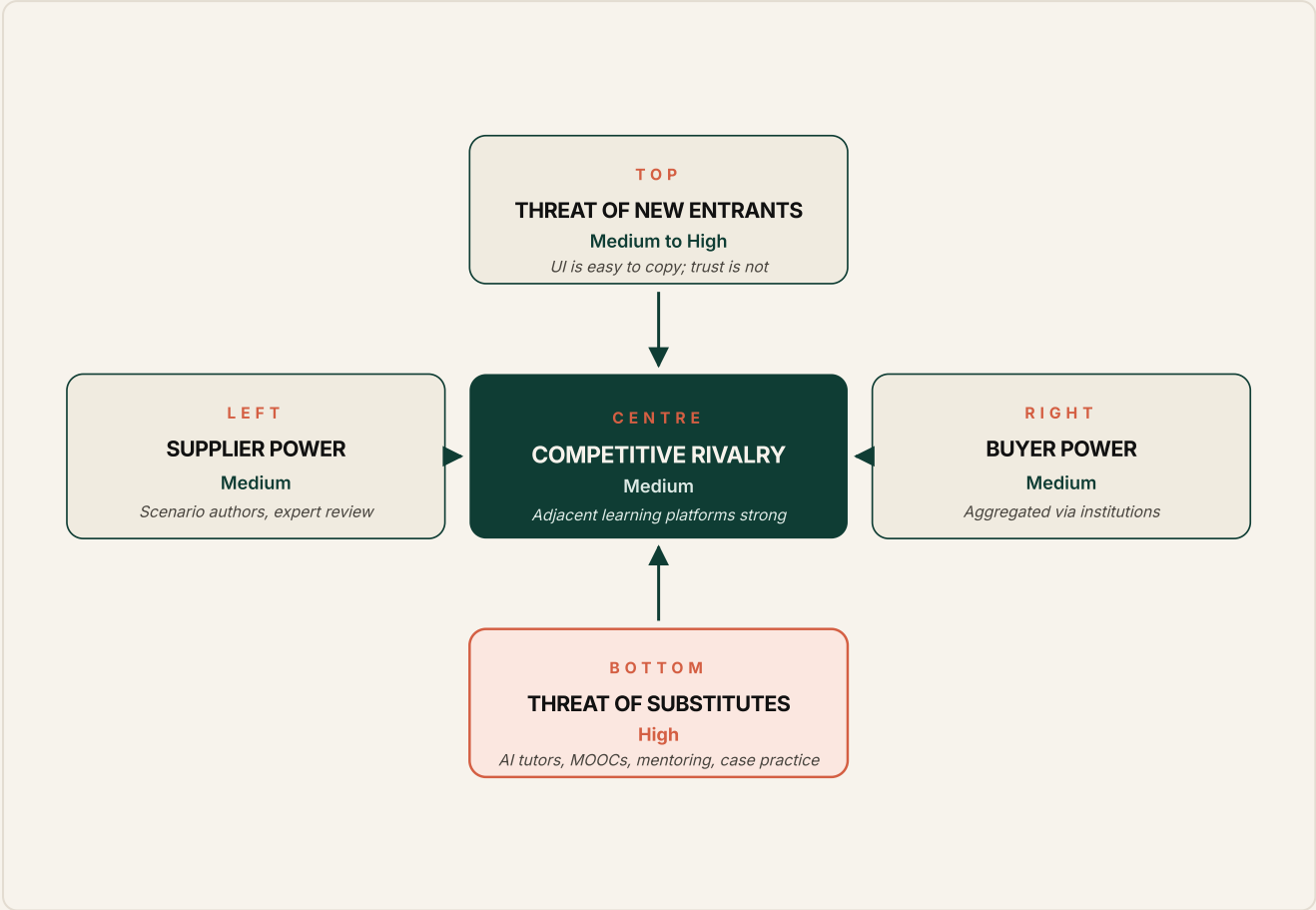


FIG. 12 Porter's Five Forces, with Acumen's interpretation of pressure on each force.

FORCE	PRESSURE	REPORT POINT
Competitive rivalry	Medium	Few direct competitors combine simulations, feedback, and peer matching; adjacent platforms are strong.
Threat of substitutes	High	AI tutors, LinkedIn Learning, Coursera, mentoring, and case practice substitute easily.
Buyer power	Medium	Students are price sensitive; universities and societies aggregate demand.
Supplier power	Medium	Scenario quality and credibility depend on expert input.
Threat of new entrants	Medium-High	UI is easy to copy; credible scoring, contextual scenarios, and network density are harder.

Where Acumen actually competes

The strongest pressure is from substitutes, AI tutors, Coursera, mentors, casebooks, all cheaper. Acumen wins, if at all, by offering what they do not: structured decisions under pressure, defensible feedback, and a peer who made the same call differently. UI clones in weeks; calibrated feedback and active network density do not.

From research to product decisions

The evidence map shows how each research finding translated into a product decision, Acumen is designed against a specific body of research, not a generic edtech idea.

RESEARCH FINDING	PRODUCT DECISION
Succession and governance are high-stakes in APAC family businesses [1][2]	Use succession and governance scenarios as flagship and premium content.
Indonesian family companies are central to GDP and market capitalisation [7]	Anchor scenario stakes in realistic regional business contexts.
Political and family ties shape decisions in regional contexts [9]	Build politically connected stakeholders into scenario decision trees.
Young users need practical business learning, not more content	Launch with short interactive simulations rather than long courses.
Serious games can support soft-skill assessment [14]	Use interactive decision simulations as the unit of practice.
Game-based assessment is used in serious professional settings [4][5]	Frame Acumen against an existing professional precedent rather than as a novelty.
Peer networks support learning and opportunity discovery	Add complementary peer matching directly to the loop.
Assessment validity takes time and data [8]	Frame scoring as research-informed, not validated, at MVP stage.

Each product decision is traceable to a finding, not intuition, and where the finding is weak the framing softens accordingly. Scoring is described as research-informed rather than validated because Imbellus and McKinsey took years and a large dataset to calibrate equivalent instruments [5][8]. The flagship scenario is anchored in the region most stressed by succession [1]; the broader library is not regionally locked, keeping the beachhead inclusive of users with no family-business context.

A balanced verdict

Acumen is a feasible early-stage MVP with a coherent beachhead, a research-backed premium pathway, and a clear product loop. Its next challenge is not building more features, but validating whether users trust and return to the simulation, feedback, and peer loop.

Where the MVP stands across four lenses

LENS	VERDICT	REASONING
Technical	Feasible	Scenario engine, weighted-tag feedback model, and profile-vector matching are implemented and stable; three scenarios live; conventional, cheap stack.
Strategic	Coherent	Reaching NextGen successors via a student/society beachhead is internally consistent and matches the literature.
Commercial	Promising, unproven	Strong on interest (15/15 likely to try) and on the problem (13/15 feel under-prepared), but no paid pilot yet, the largest open question.
Research	Backed	Leadership theory, succession evidence, and serious-games literature support the design. Scoring validation is not at Imbellus/McKinsey level [5][8]; we do not claim otherwise.

What we deliberately do not claim

The three interviews are directional and don't validate demand. Acumen offers research-backed developmental feedback, not validated psychometric assessment. CV parsing, recruiter tools, certification and fully validated scoring are all items on the roadmap after MVP.

The five hypotheses we now have to test

Listed in priority order; the first two carry the most product risk.

#	HYPOTHESIS	HOW WE WILL TEST IT	PASS THRESHOLD
H1	Users return for a second scenario within 14 days of their first.	Cohort tracking on a UCL pilot of 40+ users.	≥ 35% return rate.
H2	Users understand and trust the leadership signal without facilitator explanation.	Five-minute post-session interviews with 15 users; comprehension scoring against a four-point rubric.	≥ 12 of 15 score 3 or above.
H3	A university society will run a cohort pilot of 40+ members.	Outreach to UCL Entrepreneurs Society, UCL Investment Society, and one external society.	One signed pilot agreement by end of June 2026.
H4	Users find peer matches valuable enough to message.	Telemetry on profile views and outbound messages within the pilot cohort.	≥ 25% of completing users send at least one peer message.
H5	NextGen successors find scenario realism credible.	Three exploratory interviews with NextGen contacts via family-business advisors.	Qualitative agreement on three of four scenario realism dimensions.

SMART next steps and limits of this study

SMART recommendations for the next six months

Each action is specific, measurable, achievable, realistic, and timebound. Owners are placeholders to be filled in by the team at kickoff.

#	ACTION	MEASURE	DEADLINE	OWNER
R1	Run a 40-user UCL cohort pilot of <i>The Succession Crisis</i> with telemetry on completion, return, and peer-message rates.	40 completed sessions; H1 and H4 thresholds met.	30 Jun 2026	Maya
R2	Conduct 15 post-session comprehension interviews to test the feedback signal language.	12 of 15 score 3+ on the rubric.	15 Jul 2026	Daniel
R3	Author and ship two new scenarios (one operational, one ethical) to widen practice surface beyond succession.	Both scenarios live, expert-reviewed by a UCL faculty member.	31 Jul 2026	Moritz
R4	Ship iOS and Android builds via React Native, sharing scenario engine and feedback model with the web bundle.	Both apps in TestFlight and Play Internal Testing; smoke tests passing.	15 Aug 2026	Daniel
R5	Calibrate the feedback model against five expert raters on a held-out scenario set.	Inter-rater agreement $\kappa \geq 0.5$ on three of five dimensions.	31 Aug 2026	Daniel
R6	Sign one paying pilot with a society or course, even at a nominal price, to test willingness to pay.	One signed agreement; revenue collected.	30 Sep 2026	Maya
R7	Run three exploratory NextGen interviews via family-business advisors to begin testing the premium pathway.	Three completed interviews with notes shared internally.	31 Oct 2026	Moritz

Limitations of this study

Three limitations matter most. The primary research is small (15 survey responses, three in-depth interviews), figures in Section 7 are directional, not representative. Access to NextGen successors is second-hand: we have read the PwC and McKinsey work but not interviewed Asian family-business successors directly. The feedback model is not yet calibrated against expert ratings; Imbellus and McKinsey needed years and a substantial dataset for high-stakes calibration [5][8]. These are why scoring is framed as developmental and the cohort pilot is the most important next step.

The argument in one line

Research shows a leadership-readiness gap. Acumen tests whether short simulations can help emerging leaders practise judgement, receive useful feedback, and form valuable peer connections. The MVP demonstrates the loop is buildable. The next six months, one cohort pilot, a calibrated feedback model, a paying pilot, and three NextGen interviews, will tell us whether users return, and whether they return for the right reasons.

Business Model Canvas

The full Acumen Business Model Canvas, completed using the official Strategyzer template. The canvas describes the broad beachhead segment (students and early-career professionals) rather than the premium NextGen tier, which is treated separately in the Value Proposition Canvas overleaf.

The Business Model Canvas		Designed for: Young people looking to upskill and connect in business understanding	Designed by:	Date:	Version:	
Key Partnerships UCL societies (Entrepreneurship Society, Investment society) for cohort pilots UCL faculty for expert scenario review APAC family business advisors Cloud infrastructure providers (AWS)	Key Activities Authoring and expert review of the scenarios (editorial work that makes the products USP and value) Maintaining the typed scenario data model and scoring engines Running cohort pilots and capturing telemetry (completion, return, etc...)	Value Propositions Practise judgement on realistic scenarios under simulated pressure, not abstract case studies. A research informed leadership Signal in plain language. Peer matching by complementary, meet people whose strengths fill yours Short, repeatable sessions that fit in between lectures or commutes.	Customer Relationships Self serve digital product with cohort based onboarding (closed pilots, but not a spare public launch) Society or course partnerships rather than 1:1 sales Developmental tone, feedback is formative, not graded Channels Appstore (IOs and Google Play) Facebook (Instagram) Ads Flyers on campus Promotional event days (gamified element) UCL societies and course tie ins (primary at MVP) Word of mouth from cohort pilots Family business advisors as the route to the NextGen segment	Customer Segments Business and engineering students (UCL beachhead) Young professionals, 0-4 years from graduation Aspiring founders Premium later: NextGen successors in APAC family businesses	Cost Structure Scenario authoring + expert review - £3000-6000 Hosting and serverless infrastructure - £1000 Marketing and acquisition (UCL/society events) - £3000 Tooling, design, trademark filing, legal - £1000	Revenue Streams Individual scenario packs (£9 one off) University cohort licenses (£1500 per cohort, when product is ready) NextGen pilot programs (£8,000 per cohort - roadmapped) Not subscription, not recruiter tools, and no certificates at MVP

Make better strategic work. Playbooks that align teams and drive results.

Copyright Strategyzer AG
 The makers of Business Model Generation and Strategyzer

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 3.0 Unported License. To view a copy of this license, visit <http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/> or send a letter to Creative Commons, PO Box 1808, Mountain View, CA 94042, USA.

Strategyzer
 strategyzer.com

FIG. 13 Acumen Business Model Canvas (Strategyzer template), beachhead view.

Value Proposition Canvas · NextGen segment

The Value Proposition Canvas focuses on the premium later-stage segment, where willingness to pay is highest and the strategic stakes most acute: NextGen successors in Asia-Pacific family businesses preparing to take leadership without formal training pathways.

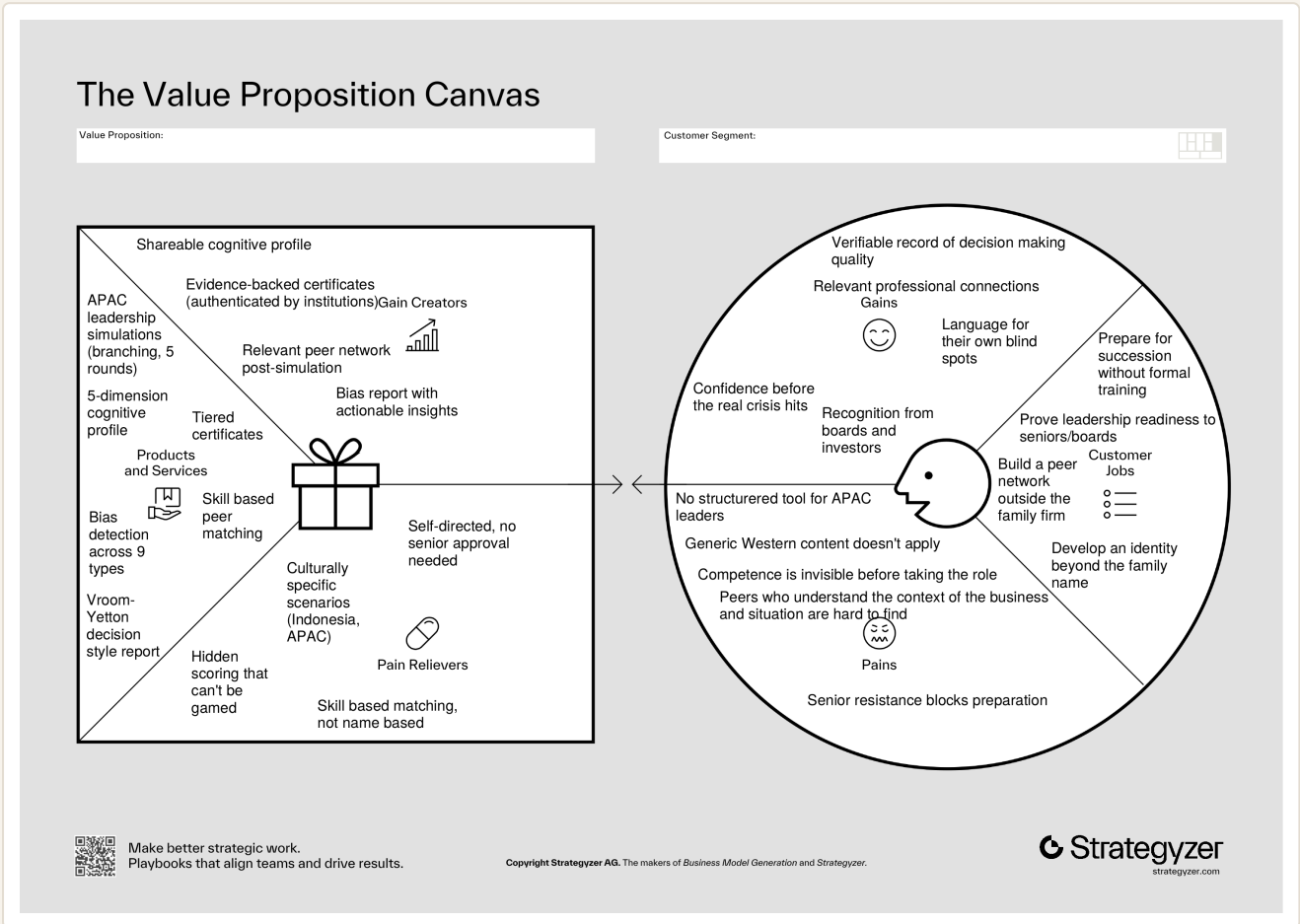


FIG. 14 Acumen Value Proposition Canvas (Strategyzer template), NextGen successor segment.

Research instruments and architecture

Interview guide · Pain points and gaps

1. What are the key skills you believe leadership and owning your own business require?
2. What do you find hardest about becoming a better leader or entrepreneur?
3. Do you feel like learning from others, especially people whose skills are different from yours, helps you grow? Or do you prefer to work independently?
4. How easy is it for you to meet people who actually challenge your thinking or complement your skills?
5. When you connect with people on platforms like LinkedIn, do those interactions actually lead to meaningful conversations?

Interview guide · Concept reaction

1. If there was a platform where you could go through real business scenarios and get feedback on your decisions, how useful would that be?
2. Have you ever been in a situation where you had to make a difficult business or leadership decision? What did you do?
3. Do you find it hard to connect with people through cold emailing, or are LinkedIn and similar networks not very in-depth?
4. Do you like simulative contextual games, and would you want to see how others with similar or contrasting situational judgement responded?
5. Would you prefer something like this to feel more like a structured course, or more like an interactive experience?

Interview guide · Profitability and value

1. If this platform could genuinely help you improve your decision-making and connect you with the right people, would you pay for it?
2. Which of these would matter more to you: certificates, skill improvement, networking opportunities, or career opportunities (if they were good)?
3. What would make you actually want to message or respond to someone on a platform like this?
4. If you could design the perfect platform to become a better leader, what would it look like?

Source audit summary

CLAIM	SOURCE
USD 5.8 trillion APAC NextGen wealth transfer	[3]
~85% of APAC firms family-owned; top 750 globally include 20% Asia-based (\$2T revenue)	[15]
~13% leadership-transition success rate, large Southeast Asian family firms	[16]
43% Indonesian NextGen citing senior resistance	[1]
PwC Global NextGen Survey 2024 sample	[2]
Serious games and soft-skill assessment	[14]
McKinsey Game-Based Innovation Lab	[4]
Imbellus / McKinsey simulation calibration	[5][8]
Political connections in Indonesia	[9]
Upper-echelons / Vroom-Yetton / Hersey-Blanchard / Rest	[10][11][12][13]

Technical architecture

Acumen runs as a static client paired with a lightweight serverless backend for scenario state and profile storage. Scenarios are authored as decision graphs with weighted dimension tags; the feedback model aggregates these into a profile vector. Peer matching uses cosine similarity over profile vectors. No production user data beyond anonymised profile vectors is held at MVP stage.

Group charter and meeting log

Required by the brief to evidence equitable contribution. The charter sets expectations; the meeting log records progress, allocation, and any mitigations.

Group charter · Group 47

MEMBER	PRIMARY REMIT	SECONDARY CONTRIBUTION
Daniel Dutulescu	Product, scenario engine, feedback model design	Technical architecture, bibliography, co-author of the report
Maya Munasinghe	Market research, survey design, validation interviews	Business model, value proposition canvas, co-author of the report
Moritz Bode	Strategy, SWOT and Porter analysis, source audit	Visual identity, MVP walkthrough, co-author of the report

WORKING AGREEMENTS

1. Decisions are taken by simple consensus; if consensus cannot be reached after one meeting, the member with primary remit decides and the disagreement is logged.
2. Each member commits to an even share of writing and review.
3. Meetings happen weekly, with a fortnightly review of allocation against deliverables.
4. If a member is unable to deliver an allocated task, the group is informed at least 48 hours before the next meeting and the task is reallocated.
5. The module leader is informed promptly if any equity issues arise that the group cannot resolve internally, in line with the brief.

Meeting log and AI use

Meeting log

DATE	MODE	PRESENT / ABSENT	DECISIONS AND ALLOCATION	MITIGATIONS
17 Mar 2026	In person	All present	Confirmed Acumen as the venture. Allocated initial research areas across leadership theory, family-business succession, and serious-games literature.	None.
24 Mar 2026	In person	All present	Reviewed initial source audit. Decided on the broader-beachhead, premium-NextGen positioning. Drafted product loop.	None.
31 Mar 2026	Online	All present	Locked the four-step product loop. Daniel started scenario engine; Maya drafted survey; Moritz started SWOT and Porter analysis.	Survey instrument shortened to seven items after pilot review.
07 Apr 2026	In person	All present	Reviewed first scenario draft (<i>The Succession Crisis</i>). Maya conducted the first exploratory interview. Confirmed visual identity direction.	Scenario length reduced from 12 to 8 decision nodes after internal playtest.
14 Apr 2026	Online	All present	Second exploratory interview. Reframed the leadership signal as developmental rather than diagnostic following interview feedback. Moved peer matching forward in the loop.	None.
21 Apr 2026	In person	All present	Reviewed full draft. Agreed on hypothesis prioritisation and SMART recommendations. Allocated final report sections.	Word count contained by moving extended notes to the appendix.
28 Apr 2026	In person	All present	Final review of report layout, citations, and source audit. Submission preparation.	None.

Use of AI tools

Generative AI was used in an assistive role consistent with UCL guidance: for drafting and editing prose, layout iteration, and proofreading. All research claims, citations, hypotheses, recommendations, primary research instruments, and the scenario library are the team's own work. The team reviewed every AI-assisted passage for accuracy and tone before inclusion.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

References

- 01 PwC (2025) *How Indonesian family businesses are preparing their legacy, and how agile they are amidst uncertainty*. PwC Indonesia.
- 02 PwC (2024) *Global NextGen Survey 2024: Asia Pacific highlights*. PwC.
- 03 McKinsey & Company (2024) *Asia-Pacific's family office boom: Opportunity knocks*. McKinsey & Company.
- 04 McKinsey & Company (2025) *From apprenticeship in space to selecting microbes: Meet McKinsey's game-based innovation lab*. McKinsey & Company.
- 05 McKinsey & Company (2020) *Innovating recruiting through online gaming*. McKinsey & Company.
- 06 EY and University of St.Gallen (2025) *Global 500 Family Business Index*. EY and University of St.Gallen.
- 07 Sukamdani, N.B. (2023) 'Family Business Dynamics in Southeast Asia: A Comparative Study of Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, and Thailand', *Journal of ASEAN Studies*, 11(1), pp. 197-218. DOI: 10.21512/jas.v11i1.9518.
- 08 Kantar, R. et al. (2018) 'Constructing Cognitive Profiles for Simulation-Based Hiring Assessments', *Educational Data Mining*.
- 09 Fisman, R. (2001) 'Estimating the Value of Political Connections', *American Economic Review*, 91(4), pp. 1095-1102.
- 10 Hambrick, D.C. and Mason, P.A. (1984) 'Upper Echelons: The Organization as a Reflection of Its Top Managers', *Academy of Management Review*.
- 11 Vroom, V.H. and Yetton, P.W. (1973) *Leadership and Decision-Making*. University of Pittsburgh Press.
- 12 Hersey, P. and Blanchard, K.H. (1969 or later edition) *Situational Leadership*.
- 13 Rest, J.R. (1986) *Moral Development: Advances in Research and Theory*. Praeger.
- 14 JMIR Serious Games (2023) 'Gamification and Soft Skills Assessment in the Development of a Serious Game: Design and Feasibility Pilot Study'.
- 15 Economic Times (2021) 'More family businesses in Asia now paying attention to leadership succession', citing the EY Family Business Survey. Available at: economictimes.indiatimes.com (accessed 2 May 2026).
- 16 NUS Business School Centre for Governance and Sustainability (2013) *Success and Succession: An Asian Family Business Report*. National University of Singapore.



ACUMEN

Practise judgement before it counts.

END OF REPORT · 1 MAY 2026